president. Modi's family, though, was not invited—once again underlining his complex private life that he had kept wrapped away from the public glare.

Modi, as he had done through the election campaign, had choreographed the swearing-in into a major news event. Just a few days earlier, in a powerful symbolic gesture, he had invited all the SAARC heads of state, including Pakistan's Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif, for the occasion. It was an unprecedented invite and a diplomatic coup—India's new prime minister was making a case on day one itself to position himself as a statesman and leader of the South Asian region. He had also sent out a subtle message to the West, especially the United States, which had targeted him in the aftermath of the 2002 riots, that their stamp of approval was not a priority. The new prime minister would make the neighbourhood his principal foreign policy thrust. Even when he did later accept an invite to visit Washington, he saw it as being entirely on his own terms. The US had denied him a visa for years, now they had bent before him—he felt vindicated.

The SAARC invite caught the ministry of external affairs (MEA) off guard—they now knew they were dealing with a prime minister who would not be chained by protocol. The SAARC initiative was a brilliant move, raising Modi's stature. Even the anti-Pakistan Shiv Sena was silenced, aware it couldn't be seen to play spoilsport. The only hitch was the extreme outdoor heat—Sharif, used to five-star comfort, could be heard complaining that he would have preferred an air-conditioned environment.

Modi was sworn in along with forty-five ministers, twenty-four with Cabinet rank. The original list, I was told, had been prepared by Modi's key point persons, Arun Jaitley and Amit Shah, then vetted by the RSS. The final touches, including portfolio distribution, were done by the prime minister himself. The choices reflected the limited pool of talent available to him but also Modi's domineering style of functioning. Jaitley, whom he implicitly trusted, was given the heavyweight finance and defence portfolios. Sushma Swaraj, whom he did not trust, was given MEA only at the last moment as a compromise. Smriti Irani, who was now seen as a